

FREE FIELD GUIDE

The 6 Levers of Engagement

A one-page guide to gamifying any lesson: without gimmicks

Why most lessons lose the room

Engagement isn't luck, and it isn't about "being fun". It comes from a small set of design levers you can pull on any lesson, in any subject. Pull two or three of them well and a flat lesson wakes up, for every learner, not just the keen ones. I've leaned on these six for years, in mainstream classes and in special education. Here they are. Print this, keep it by your planning.

The six levers

1. Clear goals, the learner always knows what they are aiming for, right now.

Ask: could every student say what "done" looks like?

2. Fast feedback, they find out quickly whether they are on track.

Ask: how soon do they know if they got it right?

3. Visible progression, they can see how far they have come.

Ask: what shows progress, a bar, levels, a map, a streak?

4. Right-sized challenge, hard enough to matter, not so hard they give up (this is "flow"). Ask: is there an easier and a harder path to the same goal?

5. Autonomy / choice, they have a real decision to make.

Ask: where does the learner get to choose task, order, or role?

6. Meaning / story, it is about something they care about.

Ask: what is the hook, a mission, a mystery, a real audience?

KEY POINT

You do not need all six. Pick the two your lesson is missing most, and change one thing for each. Small moves, big shift.

The 10-minute upgrade

STEP

1. Take one lesson you teach next week.

STEP

2. Score it 1-5 on each lever above.

STEP

3. Find your two lowest. Write one concrete change for each.

STEP

4. Teach it. Notice what changed.

One prompt to try with AI

TIP

Paste this into your AI assistant: "You help teachers gamify lessons. Here is my lesson: [paste]. Suggest one change for each of these levers, clear goals, fast feedback, visible progression, right-sized challenge, choice, meaning, kept realistic for [level]. Then give me an easier and a harder version of the main task."

A word on doing it right

Points and badges are the smallest lever, and used alone they fade fast. Aim for autonomy, competence and relatedness, let learners make choices, feel themselves getting better, and work with others. And design so the learner who usually checks out can still win: an easy path, a non-verbal way to succeed, a calmer option. Inclusion is not extra work; it is just better design.

Want the whole thing?

This one-pager is the first lever of a complete, download-ready course:

Gamification & Immersive Learning, build lessons with AI, make them playable and immersive with Delightex (AR/VR), and make them work for every learner. Full course, or start with a single mini-course (AI in Education · Game Design with Delightex · Inclusive Gamification).

NOTE

See the packages and book a training at kevinstorm.eu/curriculum. Kevin Storm · StormStudio.